aftermath of the Korean War, as well as in their debates over Indochina, American prisoners in China, and the Taiwan Strait crisis. And these developments took place as India's partnership with China and the Soviet Union—and that of the US with Pakistan—evolved. Delhi's and Washington's differences on China had adverse consequences for the relationship—they deepened the rift between the US and India or, at the very least, prevented them from bridging the gap. This chapter examines those differences and their impact on the relationship. In a final section, it also considers why those disagreements did not lead to disengagement.

Interacting in the East (1953–1954)

In the early years of the Eisenhower administration, American and Indian officials engaged on East Asian and Southeast Asian issues. They frequently found themselves at odds, often over means more than ends.

Korea: Mediating Once More (1953–1954)

The Korean War was the most urgent problem facing Eisenhower when he came to office.[4] The president and Dulles wanted to end the war that was consuming American resources and concerning US allies. At the start of the administration, to bring Beijing to the negotiating table on US terms, they increased the pressure on China and North Korea. Policymakers even considered the use of nuclear weapons to end the war. Then, suddenly, in the aftermath of Stalin's death in March 1953, China offered to exchange sick and wounded prisoners—as Delhi had proposed in 1952 and Washington had suggested the month before—and to move toward a settlement.

Eisenhower and Dulles debated whether the offer was a genuine attempt toward peace or a stalling tactic,[5] but Nehru believed the new Soviet leadership wanted to ease global tension.[6] While he often demurred from assessing the extent of Soviet sway over Chinese decisionmaking[7] and sometimes even rejected that Moscow had any influence, Nehru believed that the Chinese offer had to have had Soviet approval.[8] He did not know the precise reasons behind the change in Beijing's and Moscow's attitudes, but he welcomed it. He also appreciated Eisenhower's Chance for Peace speech in April. Nehru thought it was "a great improvement" from the first